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Boundary-Spanning in Social Movements: Antecedents and Outcomes

Dan Wang,¹ Alessandro Piazza,¹ and Sarah A. Soule²

¹Columbia Business School, Columbia University, New York, NY 10027, USA;
email: djw2104@columbia.edu, alessandro.piazza@columbia.edu

²Graduate School of Business, Stanford University, Stanford, California 94305, USA;
email: soule@stanford.edu

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Abstract

Social movement scholarship has increasingly sought to understand the relational dynamics of internal movement activity, from investigating the factors that enable movement coalitions to analyzing the trade-offs of organizational hybridity. We bring these and other related phenomena together under the label of boundary-spanning processes. Specifically, we organize research on boundary-spanning in social movements by identifying three types of boundaries that have symbolic significance as categorical demarcations: (a) issue and identity boundaries, (b) organizational boundaries, and (c) tactical boundaries. We then elucidate the tension in work that has examined how each form of boundary-spanning either promotes or hinders the realization of three important movement outcomes: (a) mobilization, (b) internal movement solidarity and scope, and (c) external social and political change. We relate our three types of boundary-spanning to these three types of outcomes in an organizing framework to locate future opportunities for research on boundary-spanning in social movements.

INTRODUCTION

In response to the recognition that social movements do not exist in a vacuum, movement scholars have moved away from studying single movements or single movement organizations, to studying the relationships between multiple movements or multiple organizations, often treating their very connections as the primary units of analysis. From this work, we have learned a great deal about the dynamics of diffusion and spillover (e.g., Meyer & Whittier 1994, Soule 1997, Strang & Soule 1998, Wang & Soule 2012), inter-organizational competition (e.g., Minkoff 1997, Olzak & Uhrig 2001, Soule & King 2008), coalition formation (e.g., Levi & Murphy 2006, Van Dyke & McCammon 2010), “osmotic” mobilization (e.g., Ferguson et al. 2017), and issue “bricolage” (Jung et al. 2014). While this research has generated a wealth of insight about inter-movement and inter-organizational interaction, we currently lack an anchoring language that unites these sometimes disparate lines of research.

Herein, we review research on when and how movement actors engage one another across categorical boundaries (Lamont & Molnár 2002, Negro et al. 2010, Glynn & Navis 2013) and how such engagement impacts social movement goals and outcomes. Our framing joins sociologists from several subfields who have investigated the dynamics of boundaries separating social actors. Although examinations of boundary formation and boundary blurring have multiplied in recent years, we focus on one influential approach pioneered by Lamont & Molnár (2002). In their review article, Lamont & Molnár (2002, p. 168) usefully define symbolic boundaries as “conceptual distinctions made by social actors to categorize objects, people, practices, and even time and space” that “separate people into groups and generate feelings of similarity and group membership.” Symbolic boundaries are thus demarcations among people or objects that help to make sense of the world around us. Similarly, drawing on Rosa et al. (1999), Glynn & Navis (2013) define “categories” as social constructions that provide a system of understanding of social phenomena. Negro et al. (2010, p. 4) further look to Durkheim & Mauss (1963) to characterize “categories as socially constructed partitions that divide the social space and the distinct meanings associated with them.”

We argue that making sense of boundary-spanning processes is essential to understanding the antecedents to social movement outcomes because movements are rarely staged in isolation of one another. Protests often attract attention and participation from constituencies that represent multiple identities and issues, bringing together diverse resources and goals (Levi & Murphy 2006). The interaction of different groups creates the possibility of transformation not only in the social and political contexts in which movements take shape but also in the very means by which activists express their grievances and even in the content of their grievances (Meyer & Whittier 1994, Polletta 1999).

Yet, few studies have attempted to form generalizable insights by comparing different types of boundary-spanning across multiple social movement contexts. Here, we draw on organizational theories of social change, which have long held that innovation occurs through blending processes that entail the novel recombination of existing parts (Powell et al. 1996, Padgett & McLean 2006). We argue that boundary-spanning processes in social movements have similar implications. Rather than describing the conditions for boundary-spanning in protest activity, one of our main goals is to synthesize research on the transformative consequences of boundary-spanning in social movements for not only society at large but also the movements themselves.

We organize our review into two sections. Motivated by Tilly & Wood’s (2013) three core features of a social movement—which we elaborate below—our first section reviews work on the precursors to boundary-spanning for three major types of boundaries in movements: (a) issue and identity, (b) organizational, and (c) tactical. We acknowledge that in many cases, these boundary

types might overlap with one another. For example, the use of strikes is highly identified with the labor movement. As such, we describe the unique components of each boundary type as well as the practical ways in which these boundaries are instantiated in movement activity.

Our second section concerns three major outcomes of boundary-spanning: (a) mobilization, (b) internal movement solidarity and scope, and (c) external social and political change. The first two outcomes correspond to the two central stages of a movement's evolution based on McAdam et al.'s (2001) *Dynamics of Contention* model: Mobilization refers to processes related to the initiation of a movement, during which challengers' aim is to attract supporters, and internal movement solidarity and scope denote the scale shift in a movement's goals and actions after a movement gains critical mass. The third outcome, external social and political change, refers to the effectiveness of a movement in reaching its goals. We conclude with a discussion of how our framework informs research on new forms of boundary-spanning in protest, such as in offline/online activism.

Our review builds on past studies of boundaries in social movements, which have primarily analyzed the construction of collective identity claims as a way of drawing symbolic boundaries within and between movements (Taylor & Whittier 1992). In particular, Taylor & Whittier's (1992, p. 111) influential discussion of the lesbian feminist movement draws on social identity theory to establish how activists use boundaries to define themselves as a challenger group, isolate their targets as dominant incumbents, and distinguish themselves from "the web of others in the contested social world." For them, boundaries that delineate collective identities originate largely from the social and political contexts in which an activist group is embedded. In other words, ascriptive features, such as race, gender, class, age, and sexuality, underpin interpretations of collective identity for most social movement actors. We build on this work by expanding the universe of boundary types (including identity-based boundaries) to shed light on organizational boundaries and boundaries between tactical repertoires, two forms of demarcation that sometimes emerge later in a movement's development than issue or identity boundaries but arguably serve just as important roles in structuring movement activity.

By identifying types of boundary-spanning and relating them to specific outcomes, we bring together past research into a framework that future scholars might use to identify new opportunities for further theoretical and empirical inquiry. Recent work has examined the consequences of movement activity that brings together different collective identities (Heaney & Rojas 2014, Fassiotto & Soule 2017), spans organizational boundaries through coalition formation (Van Dyke & McCammon 2010), and draws from different tactical repertoires (Wang & Soule 2012). However, there has not been an effort to integrate this work into a framework that also links forms of boundary-spanning to meaningful movement outcomes. Our review is therefore meant to guide future directions for scholarship to generate novel theoretical insight into related movement phenomena.

TYPES OF BOUNDARIES OR CATEGORIES IN SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

What types of boundaries delineate meaningful categories in social movements? Scholarship emphasizes that a principal goal of a social movement is to give voice to an aggrieved population, foremost through collective identity construction (Polletta & Jasper 2001). The very act of using rituals, symbols, and rhetoric to create a shared definition of a group erects boundaries not only between a movement's participants and their oppressors but also between different movements (Taylor & Whittier 1992). Through the lens of collective identity, much scholarship has analyzed how different movements take shape and the consequences of their interaction (Hunt & Benford 2007). Alongside collective identity, we add that other forms of boundaries can also create meaningful categorical structures in social movements as well.

To identify prominent forms of boundaries in movements, we take inspiration from Tilly's foundational theorization of the core characteristics of a social movement that distinguish it from other forms of collective action or social organization. According to Tilly & Wood (2013), social movements took the form that we recognize today through the simultaneous realization of three elements of public expression in the eighteenth century: first, WUNCness (i.e., self-representations of worthiness, unity, numbers, and commitment); second, embeddedness in a sustained campaign; and third, utilization of a repertoire of contention. Each element carries symbolic meaning for movement participants and observers. We argue that each element also forms the basis of meaningful boundaries that are vulnerable to spanning.

First, the WUNCness of a movement communicates why a movement exists (Tilly & Wood 2013). Each element of WUNC conveys information about the identity of movement participants and their relationship to the causes they champion. Worthiness refers to the extent to which protestors can justify that they ought to be listened to. Unity denotes consensus about a common set of issues that deserve public attention. Numbers signal that such consensus exists among large sections of a populace, which legitimizes a claim to public sovereignty. Finally, commitment refers to attitudes about activists' willingness to take costly actions to press for action on behalf of a movement. Successful WUNC displays therefore define and confer legitimacy on the core claims made in a movement. In essence, the WUNCness of a movement illustrates its collective identity by demarcating the set of grievances and concerns that participants regard as meaningful.

In addition to WUNC, Tilly and Wood argue that protest only constitutes a movement if it is part of a campaign—or a “sustained, organized public effort making collective claims on target authorities” (Tilly & Wood 2013, p. 3). Therefore, because a critical feature of campaigns is that, as a part of a well-defined program, they outlive their participants, a movement is also instantiated in the form of organizational structures that have the capacity to pass on information about mobilization or strategy to future participants (Minkoff 1997).

Finally, a repertoire of contention refers to the means by which protestors express their grievances. Repertoires contain acts and forms of public expression—such as demonstrations, strikes, sit-ins, or artistic performances—that are meant to attract attention to a movement's claims through noninstitutional means (Tilly & Tarrow 2006).

Based on Tilly's conceptualization, we suggest that (a) a movement's WUNCness is captured by the issues and identities represented by the movement, (b) the campaign features of a movement are encapsulated by the presence of organizations in the movement, and (c) a movement's repertoire is observable through the set of protest tactics typically associated with the movement. Unique sets of claims, organizations, and tactics thus not only define a movement in sharp relief against other forms of collective action but also draw boundaries between and within movements. We elaborate on the precursors to spanning for each boundary type below.

Issue and Identity Boundaries: Within and Across

Issue and identity boundaries constitute the most common way in which scholarship has categorized different social movements [see Polletta & Jasper's (2001) review of research on collective identity in social movements]. In addition to Tilly's focus on WUNCness, which centers on the issues and identities that bring forth unity among a movement's participants, a number of concepts from the social movements literature also invoke similar distinctions that incorporate definitions of collective identity. For instance, Fligstein & McAdam's (2012, pp. 10–11) theorization of strategic action fields argues that boundaries separate “socially constructed arenas” within which there exists a “cultural understanding of what forms of action and organization are viewed as legitimate and meaningful.” Fligstein & McAdam's (2012) interpretation of a strategic action field is arguably

an elaboration of McCarthy & Zald's (1977, pp. 1217–18) definition of a social movement as “a set of opinions and beliefs in a population which represents preferences for changing some elements of the social structure and/or reward distribution of a society.”

Spanning issue and identity boundaries can refer to forging ties among groups within a movement or across movements. A social movement is defined by the set of issue and identity claims most important to the participants of that social movement. Claims represent positions that movement actors take to signal support for, or opposition to, some social or political interest or some socially or politically relevant target (Soule & King 2008, Tarrow 2011, Tilly & Wood 2013, Jung et al. 2014). Although a given social movement might represent a bundle of specific claims to which participants publicly express adherence or disapproval, within a movement, there also exist different claims that might further subdivide the movement into different factions. For example, within the women's movement, some groups are more concerned with economic equality while others might focus on reproductive rights.

When actors representing different claims within a movement come together, their boundary-spanning often serves to galvanize support for the entire movement. A prominent example comes from Morris (1993), who chronicles the events that led to the city-wide civil rights campaign staged in Birmingham, Alabama, in 1963. Civil rights movement leaders in Birmingham rallied against institutionalized segregation by bringing together local groups concerned with inequality in educational access, business opportunities, and public housing to mobilize a coordinated boycott of the city's businesses and public facilities. Furthermore, the effort bridged the separate interests of local civil rights groups and the goals of the broader national civil rights movement to bring attention to their local resistance, eventually putting Birmingham at the symbolic center of the nationwide struggle for civil rights. By spanning boundaries separating specialized issues within the broader African-American civil rights movement, and by bridging local and national grievances, the Birmingham campaign became a display of widespread unity that resonated across the entire movement.

What external factors facilitate issue and identity boundary-spanning within movements? For Morris (1993), the strategic exploitation of local opportunities to unite behind a common issue—segregation in public spaces—gave rise to coalitions between various local and national civil rights groups in Birmingham. Van Dyke (2003) finds support for a similar pattern from an analysis of protest events taking place on US college campuses, suggesting that within-movement coalition formation is more likely when local threats are prevalent and when movement-specific economic resources are constrained (see also McCammon & Campbell 2002). The term local threats refers to opponents or actions that have appeal to a narrow subset of participants within a movement. For example, Meyer & Corrigan-Brown (2005) show how the impending Iraq War in 2002–2003 brought together antiwar organizations that were largely established during the Gulf War in the early 1990s. Vasi (2006) likewise demonstrates how trigger events, such as the announcement of the United States' war on terrorism in 2003, created a new set of grievances around which various peace organizations rallied. Finally, Zald & McCarthy (1980) show that the presence of a strong countermovement also inspired coalition formation within a movement.

If the existence of a common local threat is considered a demand-side factor that generates within-movement boundary-spanning across issues, resource constraints represent a corresponding supply-side factor. When resources, such as financial capital within a movement, become scarce, there is greater pressure on groups with a common movement affiliation to collaborate by entering into agreements to share those resources. For example, organizational resource constraints among women's groups in the early twentieth century fostered the formation of within-movement ties among the Women's Christian Temperance Movement and suffragists (Gusfield 1963, 1955; McCammon & Campbell 2002). Similarly, Staggenborg (1986) documents the

tension between members of coalitions among pro-choice movement organizations, showing that when external funding diminished, organizations were more likely to conduct joint campaigns. However, according to Staggenborg (1986), ideological differences between pro-choice groups could also unsettle relationships even in periods of resource scarcity.

Whereas local threats and resource constraints are primarily responsible for within-movement boundary-spanning, scholars have identified a different set of drivers for the formation of ties across the issues and identities associated with different movements. We group these drivers into two broad categories: prominent political opportunities and identity overlap. The first driver comes from political process theory, which argues that opportunities for mobilization wax and wane with the vulnerability of government authority (McAdam 1982). In periods of sweeping political transformation or regime change, the political opportunity structure opens to allow for noninstitutional voices to gain influence. Specifically, major transformative political events create highly prominent opportunities, which various activist groups seize to participate in joint cross-movement protest.

A recent example is the Women's March in January 2017, which brought together participants representing various interests, not just women's rights, to take part in a nationwide protest following the election of Donald Trump to the US presidency (Fisher et al. 2017). Similarly, protests following the announcement of the World Trade Organization (WTO) expansion in 1999 precipitated a watershed political moment that brought together activist groups representing pro-labor and environmental interests, among others (Levi & Olson 2000, Levi & Murphy 2006, Wood 2012). Finally, multiple scholars have emphasized the centrality of the twentieth-century struggle for civil rights, which held national prominence during a period of heightened protest in the 1960s (McAdam 1983). One important result of the civil rights movement was the increasing concentration of resources in the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP), Student Non-Violent Coordinating Committee, Congress on Racial Equality (CORE), and Southern Christian Leadership Conference, organizations that led the way in forging alliances with labor and peace movement groups (Isaac & Christiansen 2002).

Aside from political opportunity, alliances across movements are sometimes formed strategically when there is overlap in the identities and self-representations of participants from different movements. In particular, especially when movement participants have flexible identities, they sometimes frame their messages to appeal to broader audiences (Snow et al. 1986). A classic example comes from Meyer & Whittier (1994), who chronicle the ties between the women's and peace movements in the United States in the postwar period. Because many women also inhabited the role of mothers whose sons were drafted into service, peace movement organizations such as the Women's International League for Peace and Freedom and Women Strike for Peace frequently made "morality-based claims against war" (Meyer & Whittier 1994, p. 284). More recent work in this tradition has emphasized the diverse interpretations of women's collective identity, such as Goss & Heaney's (2010) study of the Million Mom March and Code Pink. According to their work, the Million Mom March, which united women's groups who spoke out about gun control, and Code Pink, which brought together women in opposition to the Iraq War, emphasized maternal and egalitarian frames that lent credence to their claims.

Beyond the women's movement, other research has examined links between labor and peace movement groups, such as in Carroll & Ratner's (1996) study of social movement organizations (SMOs) in Vancouver, which found that a common identification with a political-economy interpretation of injustice united groups from these two movements. Obach (2004), in a study of environmental activism, further shows how groups from the labor and peace movements, who were previously ideologically opposed, forged alliances in periods and regions in which unions

represented not only working-class but also middle-class interests, which often also incorporated environmental concerns.

Identity overlap is also invoked as a way for movements to unite multiple constituencies when core participants possess intersectional identities, that is, when they belong to more than one oppressed group (Crenshaw 1989, Goss & Heaney 2010). A wealth of contributions to this perspective comes from work on LGBTQ movements, much of which has focused on how movement participants utilized their intersectional identities to forge alliances across different social categories. Bernstein (1997) shows how political conditions characterized by openness and access to the polity allowed early LGBTQ movement groups to celebrate diversity among their constituents—a contrast to Epstein’s (1987) caution that some forms of LGBTQ activism would impose a “‘totalizing’ sameness within the group.” Similarly, Armstrong (2002) documents how the growth of the gay and lesbian movement in the United States was made possible by the emergence of “Gay + 1” organizations. Whereas the “Gay” portion referred to common sexual identities, the “+ 1” referred to additional functions (e.g., hobbyists) or identities (e.g., race) that allowed the movement to embrace intersectional identities and incorporate a diversity of identity-driven goals.

Bernstein and Armstrong’s work has since inspired a rich line of research on the strategic deployment of intersectionality in the form of boundary-spanning in LGBT activism. In particular, Gamson & Moon’s (2004) review on the topic highlights research on how “sexuality intersects and interacts with other systems of oppression” (p. 52), showing that although LGBTQ members of other aggrieved groups often face even greater challenges and stigmatization, they also are often the best positioned to forge ties across demographic categories. For example, Ghaziani’s (2008) detailed narrative comparing the experiences of four gay and lesbian rights organizations’ efforts to stage marches in Washington DC explicates the formal organizational structures through which LGBTQ movement leaders strategically exploited dissent against majority groups and inclusivity among oppressed minority groups to give rise to a broad community consciousness among LGBTQ activists.

More recently in this tradition, drawing on Internet archival materials as well as fieldwork, Terriquez (2015) chronicles the link between LGBTQ and immigrant rights movements. Specifically, Terriquez argues that the central message of LGBTQ empowerment—“coming out”—also gave rise to the movement among undocumented youth in the United States to “come out” about their legal status as a way to press for political change regarding immigrant rights. Other related work includes Saguy & Ward’s (2011) analysis of LGBTQ activists “coming out” as fat to bring attention to the stigma of being overweight. The authors drew extensively on fieldwork conducted at local and national meetings of the National Association to Advance Fat Acceptance, which provided a forum for diverse identities to come together to work toward a common goal. Together, this work contributes to our understanding of issue and identity boundary-spanning by showing how the intersectional identities of activists themselves form the basis of both boundary construction and boundary blurring in social movements.

Organizational Boundaries

Because movements are often sustained through formal organizational structures, SMOs have also fascinated many movement scholars. McCarthy & Zald’s (1977) theorization of resource mobilization emphasized the role of formal organizations in shaping the interests and actions of adherents to a particular movement. Van Dyke & McCammon (2010, p. xii) argue that “most scholarly studies of social movements fail to recognize explicitly that many, if not most, movements are amalgamations of movement organizations.” This statement builds on McCarthy & Zald’s (1977) assertion that the social movement industry (SMI), which is composed of SMOs with common

goals, is the organizational analog of a social movement. In this regard, SMOs often develop ties to other SMOs both within and across SMIs as a means of mobilizing support for their issues. As such, research on organizational category- or boundary-spanning in social movements has focused primarily on the causes of organizational coalition formation (Van Dyke & McCammon 2010, McCammon & Moon 2015, Van Dyke & Amos 2017).

Although they can incorporate any number of SMOs, coalitions can vary in their persistence. In particular, Levi & Murphy (2006, p. 655) provide a useful distinction between event coalitions, which are typically “short-lived, created for a particular protest or lobbying event,” and enduring coalitions, which represent “long-term cooperation with chosen partners.” Furthermore, event coalitions can be characterized as spontaneous and informal, whereas enduring coalitions are typically premeditated and formalized through some contract or agreement to pool resources. Levi & Murphy’s (2006) examination of the 1999 WTO protests primarily focuses on event coalitions, wherein different groups were spontaneously brought together in a concentrated period of intense protest, allowing them to share knowledge and tactics. Enduring coalitions, such as those between the major civil rights organizations of the 1960s, formalize the means of coordination. For example, McAdam et al. (2001) detail how formal and trust-based commitments between SMOs such as the NAACP and CORE helped these organizations to coordinate resource distribution to stage large-scale demonstrations and civil disobedience campaigns during the 1960s.

Given the distinction between enduring and event coalitions, some work has focused on explaining why some SMOs are more poised to form coalitions than others. One prominent line of argument suggests that SMOs that focus on broader issues or have multiple issue foci are more likely to engage in coalition formation than more narrowly focused SMOs (Obach 2004). Multi-issue organizations tend to have more robust identities that can appeal to a more diverse range of movement audiences (Padgett & Ansell 1993). As a result, broader SMOs such as Students for a Democratic Society or the National Organization for Women frequently find themselves in brokerage positions in inter-organizational collaboration networks coordinating the activity of a wide range of movement organizations (Staggenborg 1986, Van Dyke 2003). Multi-issue SMOs tend to be larger and possess a higher degree of professionalization and a greater capacity to sustain their operations than more specialized SMOs. For example, Borland (2008) finds that the division of labor associated with the greater professionalization of such SMOs makes them more adept at establishing enduring communication channels with other organizations. Here, Borland (2008) elaborates, with examples of women’s rights organizations in Buenos Aires, that larger SMOs with broader goals also have greater administrative resources to maintain coalitional alliances.

Dyadic-level characteristics also affect coalition formation among SMOs. For example, coalitions among SMOs tend to form in the presence of preexisting social ties, common identities, and political threat (Van Dyke & McCammon 2010, Van Dyke & Amos 2017). Social ties between individuals across different groups have long been identified as a central mechanism for mobilizing participation (Gould 1995, McAdam 1983). Similarly, essential to the formation of coalitions between SMOs are individuals who inhabit brokerage roles between SMOs. One example comes from Beamish & Luebbers’s (2009) study of a coalitional effort among local neighborhood activists and an outsider environmental group to stop the construction of a biodefense laboratory in Massachusetts. An enduring coalition was only made possible when members from the outsider group attended local town hall meetings, affirming their social connection with the working-class concerns of the affected local neighborhood. Brokers also played an important role in Rose’s (2000) overview of coalition building between environmental, labor, and peace organizations, as well as in Staggenborg’s (1986) analysis of alliances between pro-choice organizations.

Staggenborg’s (2015) more recent analysis of the Group of Twenty (G20) protests in Pittsburgh also illustrates the importance of preexisting formal organizational ties, which facilitated

the coordination of a broad coalition of diverse local groups opposed to the goals of the G20 meetings. By contrast, a recent investigation by Reich (2017) reverses the order of mechanisms to show how temporary co-protest ties were antecedent to the establishment of more formal alliances between SMOs. Specifically, Reich (2017) argues that the Occupy Wall Street movement was an exogenous shock that brought together activists with diverse interests for a period of intense protest. This set the stage for SMOs in New York City to forge more ties to one another through board interlocks. Importantly, Reich's (2017) study is one of the first to examine how sudden shifts in the social and political environment might affect the creation of enduring organizational coalitions.

Likewise, identity overlap among SMOs also makes coalition formation more likely, given that divergent goals often inhibit consensus development and coordination between partners. This is reflected in the observation that alliances between SMOs are more likely when they are affiliated with the same social movement than when they represent different movements (Wang & Soule 2016). For Lichterman (1995, p. 514), coalition formation among culturally diverse environmental groups was only successful when the goals of the environmental movement were framed as a "community" effort rather than a "personalized" pursuit that benefited a group's local interests. Other studies show analogously that ideological compatibility can also facilitate the creation of organizational ties (Gerhards & Rucht 1992, Bandy & Smith 2005), whereas ideological tension can cause existing ties to dissolve (Barkan 1986, Staggenborg 1986, Bystydzienski & Schacht 2001).

Finally, SMOs often band together when they come under threat from an oppositional or authoritarian force. Similar to the logic concerning within-movement boundary-spanning, the presence of political threats, repression, or direct attacks can move SMOs to unite as part of an enduring coalition. For instance, Almeida (2010) documents how collaboration between activist groups in Latin American countries intensified when oppositional political parties rose to power. Moreover, Lee (2011) demonstrates that acts of state-directed repression of protest activity also drove activist groups in South Korea to forge stronger ties with one another. Okamoto (2010) shows how pan-Asian groups joined together following violent attacks on Asians across major metropolitan areas in the United States between 1970 and 1990. In a related study, Okamoto & Ebert (2010) suggest that boundary markers between immigrants and natives encouraged immigrant activist groups to form enduring pan-ethnic ties through co-protest activity.

Tactical Boundaries

Tactics are the means and actions by which activists express their grievances. Protest tactics themselves are diverse, ranging from demonstrations and marches to vigils and artistic performances. Scholars of social protest have typically referred to tactics as part of repertoires, or sets of tactics that tend to appear in clusters associated with distinct movements and historical eras (Tilly 1978, 1995). For instance, whereas acts of civil disobedience were grouped together as a tactical repertoire associated with the civil rights movement of the 1960s, more symbolic displays, such as vigils and musical performances, were emblematic of the tactical repertoire of the activism against the United States' involvement in the Vietnam War. Of course, that a given tactic is associated with a particular movement does not prevent it from being adopted by another movement in different era (Tilly 1978; Wang & Soule 2012, 2016). In our conceptualization, spanning tactical boundaries thus refers to the adoption of tactics from different repertoires. However, the act of doing so is not simply a way to channel grievances through different methods. Adopting diverse tactics can carry symbolic implications as well.

Movement scholarship describes tactics in two ways: first, as the tools of protest; and second, as cultural symbols of collective identity. Tactics can therefore be seen as both instrumental and

expressive, in that they are enacted to pursue a movement's goals while they simultaneously build solidarity around a common identity or cultural framing. Under the first perspective, a long line of research has examined how actors come to adopt new tactics by way of a diffusion process (Strang & Soule 1998). For example, Soule (1997) explains how the shantytown protest tactic was more likely to diffuse across college campuses that had similar institutional and demographic characteristics. McCammon (2003) traces the development of a novel tactic, the suffrage parade, in the US women's movement to the diversity of organizations the movement comprised. Wang & Soule (2012) further discover that ties between SMOs facilitated the diffusion of tactics across an SMO network. Other work, such as Meyer & Whittier's (1994) examination of the nuclear freeze, shows how meetings between leaders from the women's and peace movements led to the sharing of protest strategies. In work on this topic, tactics are conceptualized as technologies, encoded in tacit knowledge, that require social ties to facilitate their transfer across movement organizations. As such, spanning boundaries between tactical repertoires entails a process of knowledge acquisition similar to that described by scholarship on organizational learning (Cohen & Levinthal 1990, March 1991).

The second perspective focuses on tactics' utility as symbols of collective identity. Here, Tilly's (Tilly 1995, Tilly & Wood 2013) perspective suggests that tactics are not simply the means to attain protest goals but are also an expression of a group's solidarity and collective identity. Multiple studies, in fact, have interpreted certain protest tactics as symbolic displays that are idiosyncratic to the ideologies and identities of white nationalist groups, labor unions, Internet activists, and feminist groups, for instance (Fantasia 1988, Polletta & Jasper 2001, Blee 2002, McCaughey & Ayers 2003).

Less is known, however, about spanning tactical boundaries when tactics are treated as cultural symbols. In other words, rather than a process that entails the absorption or learning of a new technology, as in the case of the tactics-as-tools perspective, adopting tactics from different repertoires may be interpreted as a way of signaling a shift or expansion in collective identity. On this point, Jung et al. (2014) provide a rigorous treatment of tactical repertoires as a collection of cultural symbols that become signals of ideological affinity between movements. The authors show that protest events that cross movement boundaries are more likely to occur between movements that have a moderate level of tactical overlap. Their analysis suggests an opportunity to better understand how movement groups may strategically adopt tactics to signal changes in their collective identity.

THE OUTCOMES OF BOUNDARY-SPANNING

Although research aiming to understand the antecedents to boundary-spanning largely fits into existing frameworks for explaining movement activity, such as political process theory and resource mobilization theory, empirical work on the outcomes of boundary-spanning in social movements has generated mixed results. Whereas some work has looked to theories of coalition building from political science (Levi & Murphy 2006), other research has relied on organizational theories of categorization to interpret the outcomes of boundary-spanning (Zuckerman 1999). We group the outcomes of boundary-spanning into three major categories: (a) mobilization, which refers to any action that results in the aggregation of participants and resources in support of a movement; (b) internal movement solidarity and scope, which refers to the cohesiveness and expansion of a movement's strategies, goals, and tactics; (c) external social and political change, which refers to the extent to which movement actors actually influence the actions of the state or another oppositional target.

Mobilization

The planning stages of protest often entail a high degree of coordination, requiring that movements recruit participants, amass resources, and attract attention to their efforts. These three actions represent separate dimensions of mobilization, or the process by which social movement actors garner support—in the form of financial capital, physical tools and facilities, or labor, for example—to organize public and collective expressions of their grievances (McCarthy & Zald 1977). At the core of mobilization is an organizational process, in which boundary-spanning can serve as a vital means for recruiting the participants, resources, and attention necessary to successfully make claims. Indeed, for McCarthy & Zald (1977), cooperation between movement actors often underlies the effective deployment of resources. We therefore review how past work has linked boundary-spanning to participant recruitment, resource deployment, and attention-seeking in turn.

On recruitment, past work has generally found that linkages across organizational and issue/identity boundaries enhance efforts to attract participants to take part in protest. Although Heaney & Rojas (2014) provide the clearest quantitative empirical analysis to support this perspective, other researchers have long surfaced the hypothesis that boundary-spanning can aid recruitment efforts. For instance, Curtis & Zurcher's (1973) comparison of anti-pornography organizations (APOs) in two different cities shows that stronger inter-organizational alliances in one city created a more integrated multi-organizational field, setting the stage for more coordinated recruitment efforts. Their findings also revealed that new recruits were more committed, but more homogeneous, in the city in which APOs were more integrated. Carroll & Ratner (1996) take a slightly different perspective, analyzing cross-movement networks between SMOs associated with the peace, labor, and environmental movements. In their study, cross-movement ties exposed members of SMOs to potential recruits who were already protest participants in other movements. Similar results can be found in Van Dyke's (2003) examination of student protest organizations across college campuses.

Heaney & Rojas (2014) extend this argument further to suggest that SMOs often hybridize their identities—that is, they strategically champion causes typically associated with different social movements—to appeal to broader constituencies. In their study of the antiwar movement during the George W. Bush administration, they find that SMOs with hybrid identities were more successful at recruiting participants than those with narrower identities. Instead of confusing audiences, Heaney & Rojas (2014) argue that because hybridization was a common strategy of SMOs, such SMOs benefited from legitimacy, making their boundary-spanning identity more appealing to different audiences.

Similarly, research has uncovered the benefits of boundary-spanning for the accumulation and deployment of other resources. In particular, much work has documented how inter-organizational linkages allow SMOs to coordinate their planning more effectively. The central idea builds from Coleman's (1988) observation that network cohesion facilitates lockstep coordination by enabling actors in a network to reach one another through multiple channels of communication. In social movements, Jones et al. (2001) find that inter-organizational ties can set the stage for the emergence of a hierarchical SMO superstructure within which a single SMO makes strategic and framing decisions while mobilizing other connected SMOs in a process they call network invocation. Likewise, Diani (2009) argues that inter-organizational ties bring participants into cohesive protest communities, which formalize the means to accumulate financial and organizational resources. Heery et al. (2012) show that, in the United Kingdom, links between trade unions and other SMOs also activate channels of resource mobilization. Similar patterns are found to hold in the United States, as well. Ferguson et al. (2017) show that union strength is positively impacted by

broader protest cycles via osmotic mobilization. Finally, Wang & Soule (2012) provide quantitative evidence that ties between SMOs form a critical channel through which SMOs learn about new protest tactics, documenting a diffusion process that spreads knowledge about activist strategies through co-protest ties.

Lastly, although boundary-spanning appears to benefit recruitment and resource accumulation, there is less consensus about its effects on the capacity of movement actors to engage in more protest activity to attract public attention. Attention is a critical resource for activists, in part because widespread focus on their causes exerts greater pressure on targets or policy-makers to listen to activists' claims. Moreover, because public attention is scarce, movement actors often compete with one another to attract attention, typically by staging public protests with greater frequency and more participants (Hilgartner & Bosk 1988).

On the one hand, some work shows that championing multiple issues can help movement actors gain more attention. For example, Olzak & Ryo (2007) show how diversity in goals among organizations in the environmental movement boosted attention by increasing the total volume of protest activity, in part because activists were attracted to settings that celebrate diversity (Bernstein 1997). On the other hand, Olzak & Uhrig (2001) demonstrate, with a study of the women's movement in postwar Germany, that the range of tactics used in women's rights protests has a curvilinear relationship with the level of protest activity within the movement. In particular, Olzak and Uhrig adapt Podolny et al.'s (1996) niche overlap index to measure the extent to which the set of tactics deployed in women's movement protest events is shared by other movements. They find that some tactical overlap increases protest activity, attributing the effect to the legitimization of the stakes of their protest, but a high level of overlap signals competition between movements, which puts negative pressure on total protest activity. Thus, boundary-spanning in tactics can both benefit and harm a movement's capacity to mobilize.

Internal Movement Solidarity and Scope

Whereas earlier movement theorists generally conceived of social movements as monolithic representations of a stable set of grievances, more recent scholarship has adopted the perspective that movements themselves are dynamic, such that over time, core identities and goals can change along with major shifts in tactical repertoires. Boundary-spanning processes therefore also affect a movement's solidarity (its understanding of the boundaries of its membership) and scope (the range of issues that a movement might champion and set of tactics that movement actors might deploy).

One of the most detailed analyses of how boundary-spanning relates to change in a movement's collective identity is Armstrong's (2002) aforementioned study of the LGBTQ movement in the United States. In her analysis, Armstrong details the movement's struggle for balance in upholding a movement-wide identity while still valuing the inherent diversity of the LGBTQ population. Boundary-spanning played a major role in the establishment of LGBTQ SMOs, most of which represented the interests of not only the LGBTQ movement but also at least one other social category, such as a particular religious affiliation or ethnic identity. As a result, in negotiating these various boundaries, an important outcome of the movement was the "expansion of the range of ways to express gay identity" (Armstrong 2002, p. 3).

Similarly, Ellingson et al.'s (2012) work on religiously affiliated environmental movement organizations demonstrates how the environmental protection goals of a given organization largely aligned with the values of the religion with which it was affiliated. However, not all boundary-spanning processes lead to the expansion of a movement's collective identity. Croteau & Hicks's (2003) study of the homelessness movement shows that when SMOs form coalitions, they must

frequently make a choice between their own identities and the collective identity of the coalition, which sometimes come into conflict.

When it comes to tactical choice, recent scholarship has emphasized how boundary-spanning can expand the tactical repertoires that movement actors can access. Taylor & Van Dyke (2004) offer an extensive review of how tactical repertoires shift over time because of internal and external movement dynamics, emphasizing how different forms of organizing, ranging from hierarchical to decentralized, can expose movement actors to different sets of tactics. In a more recent investigation, Wang & Soule (2016) draw on organizational theories of technological innovation to show that multi-issue protests—that is, protest events that make claims from different social movements—are more likely to be sites of a particular form of tactical innovation. Specifically, multi-issue protests are fertile ground for diverse tactics to come together as part of a novel recombination. By contrast, peripheral protest events, which have narrow appeal, are more likely to introduce tactics that are novel or rarely used. Wang & Piazza (2016) propose a more strategic perspective by suggesting that spanning movement boundaries creates a trade-off in tactical choice. Although multi-issue protest events garner more attention and have a greater capacity for resource mobilization, they also are accountable to more diverse constituencies. Thus, although greater resource mobilization allows multi-issue protests to deploy more disruptive and impactful tactics, those tactics are also less likely to entail violence or property damage.

Therefore, concerning internal movement change, boundary-spanning increases the exposure of movement actors to more diverse partners and audiences, which can make their collective identities more flexible and broaden their tactical repertoires. However, some research suggests that this process does not transpire without trade-offs. Boundary-spanning can also place constraints on the expansion of collective identity and tactical deployment by making conflicts between different associated groups more salient.

External Social and Political Change

Lastly, although scholarship on category- and boundary-spanning in the social movements literature has burgeoned in recent years, specifying if and how it impacts the social and political outcomes sought by movements remains a nascent area of investigation. We therefore echo the sentiment of scholars who examine coalitions (e.g., McCammon & Moon 2015) in noting that there are many opportunities for research on the consequences of boundary-spanning.

On the one hand, engaging in cross-movement boundary-spanning can galvanize new support for a waning movement, revitalizing its efforts against incumbent targets. Isaac & Christiansen (2002), for example, find that labor unions' intensified relationship with the civil rights movement after 1960 allowed them to win greater concessions from employers (see also Isaac et al. 2006, Dixon et al. 2013). Evans & Kay (2008) similarly find that although politically weak, US environmental groups were able to influence the negotiations on the North American Free Trade Agreement by borrowing tactics and frames from trade policy groups. In particular, by defining environmental issues as trade issues, pro-environment SMOs experienced greater success in pushing for a more environment-friendly set of agreements. Beamish & Luebbbers (2009) likewise argue that the alliance between neighborhood groups [i.e., NIMBY (not in my back yard) activists] and national pro-environment organizations was central to halting the construction of a local biodefense laboratory in Massachusetts because it created pressure against multiple stakeholders who were beholden to the laboratory's establishment.

On the other hand, some scholarship has shown that boundary-spanning across issues, identities, and tactical repertoires can backfire. Gamson (1975), for example, argues that because activists are strategic actors, adopting multiple identities can make protest groups even more vulnerable

to competition from other protest groups seeking attention from the same set of resources and participants. In other words, because the public's attention is a scarce resource, movement actors stand to benefit mainly by differentiating from one another. By specializing in a narrow set of claims, SMOs would therefore face less competition. Supporting this view, King & Cornwall (2005) show that during the women's suffrage movement, groups that championed a narrow set of issues, rather than incorporating a diverse set of claims, experienced increasing returns to learning (see also Soule & King 2008). Similarly, McVeigh et al.'s (2004) study of the Ku Klux Klan demonstrates that a narrower framing of their claims around economic issues resonated with local populations more, helping white nationalist groups gain more influence in local politics. Cress & Snow (2000) likewise find that narrower frames were associated with the greater capacity of homeless activists to secure desired outcomes.

More recently, Fassiotto & Soule (2017) show that within the women's movement, the protest events that make claims from other movements are less effective in attracting attention from congressional lawmakers in the United States than those that make more focused claims. Relying on reasoning from organizational ecology, they argue that presenting an audience with multiple issues can lead to confusion, leading to a lower evaluation of each component issue (Zuckerman 1999, Hsu & Hannan 2005). Rather than explaining the benefits of issue focus for protest effectiveness, Fassiotto & Soule (2017) theorize about the negative ramifications of issue breadth. By applying a cognitive mechanism to our understanding of why multi-issue movement efforts might fail, Fassiotto & Soule (2017) introduce a more generalizable justification for the risks of cross-movement alliances that does not rely on issue- or resource-specific characteristics. In a similar vein, Olzak's (2016) study of terrorist organizations shows that those organizations with ideological clarity are better able to execute lethal violence and survive longer than those with a more blended ideology.

ONLINE/OFFLINE ACTIVISM AS AN EMERGENT FORM OF BOUNDARY-SPANNING

Although much social protest still takes place in conventional arenas, social movements have increasingly turned to the Internet (Luo et al. 2016, Powell et al. 2016), recognizing both its potential as a mobilization tool (Lewis et al. 2014) and its importance as an arena of social and political contestation (Earl 2006). We contextualize research in this area as an instantiation of an emergent type of category- or boundary-spanning in social movements: that which occurs between online and offline activism. While some forms of protest take place entirely over the Internet, such as the Kony2012 online campaign against Ugandan warlord Joseph Kony (Hara & Huang 2011), most SMOs blend online and offline activism through the use of social media and smartphone communication (Dailey 2012). For example, online platforms such as Twitter or Facebook, as well as cross-platform instant messaging systems such as WhatsApp, can be used for coordination as well as to broadcast information about protest events and to rally support for the activists' causes (Earl & Kimport 2008).

Some prominent examples of digitally enabled forms of protest from the recent past include the 2011 Egyptian revolution, where Twitter played a pivotal role (Lynch 2011, Tufekci 2017), the Occupy Wall Street movement, which has been described as the United States' first "true social-media uprising" (Democracy in America blog 2011), and the 2010 revolution in Tunisia (Gerbaudo 2012). In all of these cases, boundary-spanning between online and more traditional, offline modes of activism allowed SMOs to work toward their goals by disseminating information about their activities and by increasing awareness of collective action efforts among the general public, thus catalyzing mobilization (Tufekci & Wilson 2012). Furthermore, the hybridization of

online and offline tactics increases the costs of repression by broadcasting protest activities more broadly, making state actors more accountable to the general public for their actions.

Online protest tactics also span a disruptiveness continuum ranging from relatively benign, nondisruptive form of protests (such as petitions) to so-called hacktivism, which aims to cause major outages in the organizational functions of targets (Taylor & Jordan 2004). Notable examples of hacktivism in the past decade have come from Anonymous, a loosely structured international collective of hackers known for its publicity stunts and distributed denial of service attacks on websites associated with corporations, religious organizations, or national governments (Scott 2013, Dobusch & Schoeneborn 2015). The case of Anonymous is especially germane to our discussion because the organization has often used its expertise to assist other movements, most notably the Occupy Wall Street and the Arab Spring campaigns, forming cross-movement linkages spanning national, cultural, and technological boundaries.

Although research on online activism has grown, it lacks a cohesive framework for understanding how an online presence might facilitate or hinder offline boundary-spanning activity. For example, social media virality can expand the reach of movements such as the use of the “Black Lives Matter” hashtag on Twitter, but does its diffusion also facilitate offline coordination among African-American civil rights groups and other groups (Ince et al. 2017)? In other words, while it is well documented that Internet technologies can help to foment spontaneous event-based uprisings such as the Arab Spring, what role does online engagement play in creating more enduring linkages across movement and organizational boundaries (Bennett & Segerberg 2014)? Answering these questions is vital to bridging existing social movement research on boundary-spanning and scholarship on new forms of protest and mobilization.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

Table 1 summarizes our synthesis of the literature on boundary-spanning processes in social movements. We categorize the work we have reviewed based on the valence of the association between a given type of boundary-spanning and a type of movement outcome. It is impossible for our review to collect every form of boundary-spanning documented in movement scholarship, but the comparison across cells in **Table 1** reveals several opportunities for future research, which we hope will prove fruitful for our understanding of how internal movement dynamics relate to the effectiveness of social protest.

First, most research on social movements has focused on how actors span issue and identity boundaries or organizational boundaries with little work on spanning boundaries between tactical repertoires. Arguably, the emphasis on organizational as well as issue and identity boundaries results from a clearer shared understanding of how to define a social movement and an SMO. By contrast, tactical repertoires are more fluid. Moreover, although a given set of tactics might be symbolically associated with a certain movement—such as the sit-in being closely tied to the African-American civil rights movement—there is no institutional force that entitles a certain group to the exclusive right to use a specific tactic, and many tactics are designed to be modular (Tarrow 2011).

However, as Jung et al. (2014) suggest, rather than viewing tactics as the technologies of social protest, it might be more productive for movement researchers to instead characterize them as the cultural symbols of protest. The topology of social protest might then be described by clusters of protest tactics that signify cultural similarity. When an activist group adopts tactics across different clusters, we might interpret this action as an attempt to broaden the group’s cultural resonance. Future scholarship might even reexamine past work on changes in tactical repertoires as signals of shifts in cultural identities.

Table 1 Summary of literature

Effect on movement outcome	Type of boundary-spanning			
	Issue and identity		Organizational	Tactical
	Within movement	Across movement		
Mobilization				
Positive	Taylor & Whittier (1992), Morris (1993), Van Dyke (2003), Meyer & Corrigan-Brown (2005), Vasi (2006)	McAdam (1983), Carroll & Ratner (1996), Meyer & Whittier (1994), Isaac & Christiansen (2002), Obach (2004), Levi & Murphy (2006), Goss & Heaney (2010), Heaney & Rojas (2014), Fisher et al. (2017)	Curtis & Zurcher (1973), Diani (2009), Heery et al. (2012), Ferguson et al. (2017)	
Negative	Staggenborg (1986)			
Internal movement solidarity and scope				
Positive	Jones et al. (2001), Armstrong (2002)	Ghaziani (2008), Saguy & Ward (2011), Terriquez (2015), Wang & Soule (2016), Wang & Piazza (2016)	Gerhards & Rucht (1992), Carroll & Ratner (1996), Jones et al. (2001), McAdam et al. (2001), Bandy & Smith (2005), Wang & Soule (2012)	Jung et al. (2014)
Negative	Croteau & Hicks (2003)	Wang & Piazza (2016), Wang & Soule (2016)	Staggenborg (1986), Lichterman (1995), Bystydzienski & Schacht (2001), Croteau & Hicks (2003), Almeida (2010), Okamoto (2010), Lee (2011)	
External social and political change				
Positive	Morris (1993)	Isaac & Christiansen (2002), Isaac et al. (2006), Olzak & Ryo (2007), Dixon et al. (2013)	Staggenborg (1986), Rose (2000), Beamish & Luebbers (2009)	Evans & Kay (2008)
Negative	Cress & Snow (2000), McVeigh et al. (2004), King & Cornwall (2005)	Gamson (1975), Fassiotto & Soule (2017)		

Second, whereas much work has documented the benefits of boundary-spanning for mobilization and protest effectiveness, only recently has scholarship begun to reveal the constraints and possibly negative effects of boundary-spanning. Internal movement conflicts have been documented across a variety of movement settings, including the US women's movement (Staggenborg 1986) and the Chinese Red Guard youth movement (Walder 2009). Most of this work attributes disagreement to inherently conflicting ideological stances of groups within a movement. However, movement scholarship has not systematically investigated whether attempts to bridge divides between opposing factions or even parties that simply represent different interests might further imperil a movement's efforts to press for social and political change. Recent studies locate a cognitive basis for the potentially negative effect of boundary-spanning on attaining movement goals (Fassiotto & Soule 2017). We argue that future work should more rigorously examine other sources of constraint, such as whether boundary-spanning leads to greater coordination costs or the misaligned perceptions of commitment.

We provide a useful framework in which future researchers of social movements might situate and contextualize their discoveries. In doing so, we join a chorus of new research on social movements that is sensitive to the relational—versus the oppositional—dynamics of protest activity. Much of this work is concentrated in empirical investigations of coalition formation among SMOs (Van Dyke & McCammon 2010, Reich 2017, Van Dyke & Amos 2017). We emphasize that our boundary-spanning processes do not just apply to an understanding of how SMO coalitions form, but also how movement actors conceptualize the breadth of their goals and the resources they can mobilize. In other words, boundary-spanning in social movements does not just refer to the establishment of alliances between formal protest groups; singular movement actors can also engage in boundary-spanning by expressing a multi-issue identity or aligning themselves with different constituencies (Wang & Soule 2016).

Boundary-spanning processes are pervasive in social movements. Rarely do movement actors engage in protest activity in a vacuum. The survival of activist groups depends critically on the support from other groups. Boundary-spanning processes are therefore often at the center of mesomobilization efforts that can lead to society-wide campaigns to create social and political change. We hope that by focusing attention on the relational factors that underlie boundary-spanning in social movements, we will encourage scholarship that further elucidates the mechanisms that link microinteractional phenomena to macrosocial transformation.

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